



Western red deer
(*Cervus elaphus*)
Height at shoulder: up to 4 ft 3 in (1.3 m)
Body length: up to 8 ft 9 in (2 m)

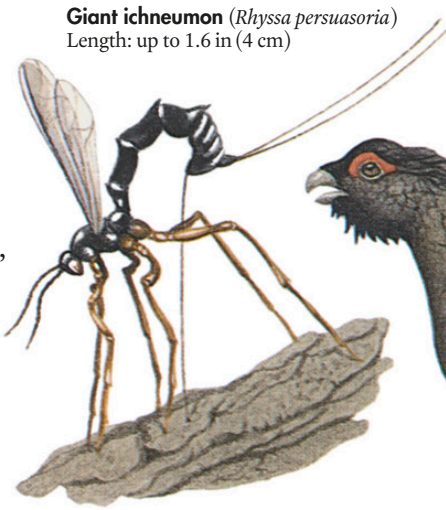
Smelly protection

If it is threatened, the polecat produces a foul-smelling liquid from glands under its tail. The polecat also uses this scent to mark its territory. Polecats do not hibernate, and hunt for small mammals all year round.

Polecat (*Mustela putorius*)
Body: up to 18 in (46 cm)

Eaten alive

The female giant ichneumon lays her eggs next to the larvae of wood wasps, which the young grubs feed on when they hatch. Because wasp larvae tunnel deep inside tree trunks, the ichneumon drills through the wood with an egg-laying tube, which is 1.5 in (4 cm) long.



Giant ichneumon (*Rhyssa persuasoria*)
Length: up to 1.6 in (4 cm)

Antler fights

In the fall mating season, called the rut, the male red deer fights rival males with his antlers to win females for mating. He sheds his antlers each spring. New ones grow in time for the next mating season.

Flying acrobat

The pine marten is an acrobatic and swift nighttime hunter. It has strong legs, broad pads, and long claws that help it climb, and its bushy tail helps it balance. It eats many things, from small birds to rats, beetles, and fruit. It hunts on the ground and in the trees.



Western capercaillie
(*Tetrao urogallus*)
Length: up to 3 ft 9 in (1.15 m)



Dancing display

In spring, the male capercaillie puts on a display to attract females. He fans out his tail, points his neck upward, and makes odd gurgling sounds. He may even jump and clap his wings. Displaying capercaillies are very aggressive and will threaten deer, sheep, or even humans who disturb them.

European pine marten
(*Martes martes*)
Body length: up to 23 in (58 cm)



KILOMETERS
0 100 200 300 400
MILES
0 100 200



Winters in the forests are bitterly cold, with snow covering the ground for up to half the year.



The many lakes in the northern European forests provide animals with places to drink.



Many European conifer forests have been planted by people and are harvested for their timber.